

COMPERATIVE STUDY ON THE USE OF KISWAHILI AS AN OFFICIAL LANGUAGE IN KENYA AND TANZANIA: THE BEST, GOOD, BAD AND THE WORST SCENARIO

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Abstract

This study was conducted to assess the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya and Tanzania. Systematic observations of how Kiswahili is spoken and used in official communications were made in rural and urban areas. Content analysis was used to interpret the observations. Results of the observations were triangulated to identify common themes among the four researchers involved in the process. The four researchers agreed that the scenario in the use of Kiswahili is good in Tanzania and bad in Kenya and recommended that section of the Kenya Constitution be revised to make Kiswahili the only official language in Kenya. It also recommended that the government of Tanzania should start the process of making Kiswahili an official language. Key words Kiswahili, official language

Introduction

Evidence on the use of national languages shows that most countries use indigenous languages as official national languages. This is mainly because using an indigenous language as a national language has a great impact on national activities. Kiswahili is spoken in Kenya, Tanzania, Uganda, Democratic Republic of Congo, Rwanda and Burundi. We decided to investigate the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Tanzania and Uganda in May 2025. Paul is a Kenyan. He studied in Kenya and Uganda, lives in Kenya and worked in universities in Kenya and Tanzania. Bahiya is a Tanzanian. She studied in Tanzania and Uganda and lives and works in Tanzania. Available evidence shows that countries experience rapid social and economic development and national integration by using indigenous languages as official national languages. In these countries an indigenous language is used as a language of instruction in basic and higher education, in parliament, public offices, meetings and official correspondence. The opposite is happening in Kenya. There are those who fear that making Kiswahili the only language will adversely affect foreign investment and the job opportunities of the elite. They therefore, treat it as a threat. For ordinary people making Kiswahili the only official language that is long overdue, some East African scholars have argued that based on a review of trends worldwide, East African countries should adopt Kiswahili as the only official language.

It is against this background of issues and debates that this study was conducted. The central challenge in the use of Kiswahili as an official language in East Africa is the stark contrast in the speaking of Kiswahili across East and Central Africa. Speaking of Kiswahili by residents of urban areas is becoming the norm. Yet parliament and government of Kenya continue to use English as an official language and schools use it as a language of instruction. This is the dilemma. Kiswahili must now be used as the only official language in Kenya.

A national language is supposed to be used in the following ways:

1. It should be the only language that is used in parliament, county assemblies, public functions and government offices.
2. It should be the only language to be used as a language of instruction in education institutions.
3. It should be the working language of all courts.
4. All the wording on bank notes should be in it.
5. Instructions on medicine should be printed in the language.
6. Passports and national identity cards should be written in the language.
7. Forms in public offices should be in the language.
8. Government circulars should be in the language.
9. Immigration office should issue forms in the language.

The following are other ways of using a national language in urban and in rural and urban areas of a country.

1. During religious services.
2. Government and businesses place advertisements.
3. Newspapers
4. Television broadcasting
5. In business places

Based on the review of policy analysis techniques from other countries, the researchers identified the ways listed above as areas of concentration for analysis in the comparative study of the use of Kiswahili as an official language in Kenya and Tanzania

Research Problem

The use of a local language as an official language has grown in popularity since African and Asian countries got independence from European colonial rule. Review of literature has shown that no study has been conducted to assess the extent to which Kiswahili is used as an official language in Kenya and. Therefore, this study assessed the use of Kiswahili as an official language in Kenya and Tanzania.

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to answer how the use of Kiswahili in Tanzania, Kenya and Uganda differ and how Tanzanian practices might improve those of Kenya and Uganda. Besides many similarities between the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Tanzania and Kenya, there are striking contrasts between the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya and Tanzania. For example, while Tanzanian primary school students use Kiswahili as a language of instruction, English is used as a language of instruction in primary schools in Kenya.

Research Questions

The following questions guided their study:

1. To what extent is Kiswahili used as an official language in Kenya and Tanzania?
2. What are the similarities and differences in the use of Kiswahili as an official language in Tanzania and Kenya?
3. What are the barriers to the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya and Tanzania ?
4. What initiatives should be established to promote the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya and Tanzania?

Significance of the Study

As a response to the challenges and dilemmas facing the use of Kiswahili as an official language in Kenya, the researchers decided to conduct a comparative study of the use of Kiswahili as an official language in Kenya and Tanzania. It is hoped that the results of this study will enable senior government political leaders to promote the use of Kiswahili as an official language in member countries of the East African Community.

Methodology

This study is qualitative in nature utilizing case study research design.

Target Population

The target population was all counties/districts in Kenya and Tanzania.

Description of the Sample and Sampling Procedures

The sample consisted of parliaments, several public offices and public functions. Purpose sampling technique was used to sample.

Research Instruments

Observation guides were used to collect data.

Data Collection Procedures

The researchers visited different government institutions, attended public functions and participated in different public activities to assess the extent to which Kiswahili was being used. This approach provided a diversity of information for assessment of the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya and Tanzania.

Data Analysis Procedures

Data were analysed using categories, themes and patterns.

Results

Introduction

When it comes to the use of Kiswahili in Kenya and Tanzania, there is the best good, bad and the worst scenario.

The Use of Kiswahili as an official Language in Kenya

The extent to which Kiswahili is used as an official language ... The Constitution of Kenya made Kiswahili one of the two official languages. The other language is English. However, to a large extent Kiswahili is not used as an official language in most cases Kenya has two big reasons for using Kiswahili as an official language. First, available evidence shows that a vast majority of Kenyans speak Kiswahili.

Second by using Kiswahili, most people will understand what is spoken in public meetings and participate effectively in discussions. Teachers will effectively teach learners and students will understand what is taught.

The Best Scenario

Kiswahili is a compulsory subject in secondary schools.

The Good Scenario

1. Members of Parliament speak in English as well as Kiswahili.
2. The head of state and other government political leaders speak in public functions in English as well as Kiswahili.
3. During public functions, participants may choose to speak in Kiswahili or English.
4. Kiswahili is used in government offices as well as English.
5. Kiswahili is used in courts.
6. Passports are written in English as well as Kiswahili.
7. Kiswahili is used in business places.
8. In urban areas, religious service is provided in English as well as Kiswahili. In rural areas, religious service is provided in the local language as well as Kiswahili.
9. Television broadcasts are in English, Kiswahili as well as local languages.

The Bad Scenario

1. In Kenya Kiswahili is not used by most Members of Parliament during parliamentary sessions. Only Members of Parliament from the former coast province speak Kiswahili in Parliament.
2. Most newspapers are written in English.

The Worst Scenario

Available evidence shows that although Kiswahili is an official language in Kenya English is used in the following ways:

- English is the only language of instruction at all levels of the education system.
- Government circulars are in English.
- National identity cards are written in English.
- Wording on bank notes is in English.
- Immigration office issues forms in English.
- Instructions on medicine are in English.
- In county assemblies members mainly speak in English.
- Although the language policy of 1977 requires teachers to use mother tongue as a medium of instruction in lower primary most teachers teach in English.
- In national public functions, political government leaders and top government officials address participants in English.
- In courts advocates, magistrates and judges speak English.

Barriers to the Use of Kiswahili as Kenya's Official Language

The following are barriers to the use of Kiswahili as a national language in Kenya.

1. Successive heads of state have failed to use their authority to ensure that the policy that made Kiswahili a national language is effectively implemented.
2. Successful use of a language as a national language requires more than speaking the language once while in parliament. It requires the use of Kiswahili in many ways.
3. The reluctance of civil servants to use Kiswahili in their places of work.
4. Failure by Kenya policy makers in education to devise policies and strategies needed to make Kiswahili a language of instruction at all levels of the education system.
5. Absence of presidential leadership, genuinely commitment to the use of Kiswahili as an official language.
6. Pressure from Great Britain and the United States of America on the government to continue using English as an official language.
7. Failure by Kenya's scholars and academics to assess the leadership in Kenya on its commitment to making Kiswahili the only official language in Kenya.
8. Making Kiswahili the only official language is difficult. Due to globalization and other factors, Kenya and other African countries are being persuaded to adopt English as the only official language.

9. These and other barriers need to be addressed carefully, for example, making Kiswahili a language of instruction at all levels of the education system requires upgrading Kiswahili knowledge and skills of teachers and lecturers. This however, has budgetary implications.

Recommendations

1. The Constitution of Kenya should be amended to make Kiswahili the only official language. The biggest reason for continued use of English as Kenya's national language is that Kenya is a former British colony and its ruling elite like speaking English in public functions. Members of Parliament have a duty to make Kiswahili the only national language.
2. Kenya Parliament should pass a law to make Kiswahili the only language to be used in parliament, county assemblies and public functions. This arrangement should not be changed without a two-thirds majority in parliament. It implies printing all the wording on new bank notes in Kiswahili, instructions on medicine to be printed in Kiswahili and national identity cards to be written in Kiswahili.
3. The working language of all courts should be Kiswahili which means that for the first five years, there will be need for interpreters.

USE OF KISWAHILI AS OFFICIAL LANGUAGE IN TANZANIA

The Constitution of Tanzania recognizes Kiswahili as the National and official language. Kiswahili is also accompanied with English, where English is used for certain formal circumstances. Kiswahili is widely used in official, educational, political, legal and social spheres in Tanzania. However, there are still cases where English dominates, especially in higher education and certain government functions.

Tanzania has strong reasons for promoting Kiswahili as the official language.

- Large majority of Tanzanians are fluent in Kiswahili, making it the most unifying language across ethnic and regional lines. It is also the language used in daily communication, media as well as government outreach.
- Using Kiswahili enables mass participation in governance, education and National development. It makes communication accessible and inclusive, especially in rural communities. Teachers can instruct effectively and citizens can participate in National debates and understand public policies.

The Best Scenario

- Kiswahili is the language of instruction in primary schools.
- It is a compulsory subject at all levels of education, including secondary and teacher training colleges.
- Most government documents are written in Kiswahili.
- Public and National functions are conducted in Kiswahili.

The Good Scenario

- Parliamentary sessions are conducted in Kiswahili.
- The President and other National leaders often give speeches in Kiswahili.
- Government offices use Kiswahili for communication and service delivery.
- Kiswahili is widely used in radio, television, and newspapers.
- Kiswahili is used in religious services across the country, both in urban and rural areas.
- Court proceedings, especially at the lower levels can be conducted in Kiswahili.
- Passports and National ID cards includes Kiswahili.
- Kiswahili is spoken in business and marketplaces.
- Kiswahili is used in campaigns, civic education and political mobilization.

The Bad Scenario

- In higher education (colleges and universities), English remains dominant, especially as the language of instruction and research.
- Legal proceedings in higher courts often take place in English.
- Official circulars from ministries and departments may still be written in English.
- Some medical instructions and government forms are not translated into Kiswahili.

The Worst Scenario

- Despite the strong presence of Kiswahili, some key areas still rely heavily on English:
- Most university programs, especially in science and technology, are delivered in English.
- Research publications and academic work are predominantly done in English.
- Government policies and strategic documents are sometimes issued in English without Kiswahili versions.
- International partnerships and donor-funded projects encourage the use of English in implementation.

Barriers to the Full Use of Kiswahili as Tanzania's Official Language

- Some government officials and professionals still prefer English in formal communication, believing it shows prestige or global relevance.
- The education system still lacks adequate materials and vocabulary in Kiswahili for advanced science and technical subjects.
- Inadequate investment in training teachers and lecturers to teach all subjects in Kiswahili, especially at secondary and tertiary levels.
- Globalization pressures push English as the language of international business, science and diplomacy.
- Some academics and policymakers view Kiswahili as inadequate for scholarly and technical discourse.
- There is still a colonial legacy where English is associated with elite status and upward mobility.
- Budgetary constraints hinder the full translation and dissemination of government content in Kiswahili.
- The legal system often favors English, especially in the Court of Appeal and High Court.

Similarities

1. Kiswahili is a compulsory subject at all levels of basic education
2. Kiswahili is widely used in radio and television
3. Kiswahili is widely used in religious services in urban areas
4. Kiswahili is spoken in business and market places
5. Kiswahili is used in campaigns and political mobilization in urban areas.
6. Kiswahili is used in courts

Differences

1. Kiswahili is the language of instruction in primary schools in Tanzania while in Kenya English is the language of instruction in primary schools.
2. Public and national functions are conducted in Kiswahili in Tanzania while in Kenya they are conducted in English and sometimes in Kiswahili.
3. Most government documents are written in Kiswahili in Tanzania while in Kenya they are written in English. Although some members of parliament speak in Kiswahili, parliamentary

sessions in Kenya are conducted in English while in Tanzania parliamentary sessions are conducted in English.

Conclusion

Tanzania has made some progress in elevating Kiswahili as a national and official language. It is one of the most successful examples in Africa of promoting an indigenous language for National unity and development. However, to realize the full benefits of Kiswahili as a tool for inclusiveness and identity, more effort is needed to address the existing barriers especially in higher education, science and governance. Continued investment in Kiswahili development, teacher training, translation and policy reform will help Tanzania consolidate its leadership in African linguistic identity.

Initiatives that should be established to promote the use of Kiswahili as a national and official Language in Kenya

1. The constitution of Kenya should be amended to make Kiswahili the only official language. The biggest reason for continued use of English as Kenya's national language is that Kenya is a former British colony and its ruling elite like speaking English in public functions. Members of Parliament have a duty to make Kiswahili the only national language
2. Kenya Parliament should pass a law to make Kiswahili the only language to be used in parliament, county assemblies and public functions. This arrangement should not be changed without a two-thirds majority in parliament. It implies printing all the wording on new bank notes in Kiswahili, instructions on medicine to be printed in Kiswahili and national identity cards to be written in Kiswahili.
3. The working languages of all courts should be Kiswahili which means that for the first five years, there will be need for interpreters.

Initiatives that should be established to promote the use of Kiswahili as a national and official Language in Tanzania

1. Tanzania parliament should pass a law to make Kiswahili the only language to be used as a medium of instruction at all levels of the education system and in courts and offices.
2. The government should allocate adequate funds for translation of government documents from English to Kiswahili
3. English should be taught as a second language in schools

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